

2027 Budget Hearing Afternoon Session - September 9th, 2026

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2yjFcbfhnbl
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Delaware County Municipal Budget Review & Meeting Summary

Meeting Date & Context: Budget Hearings Session (Continuing Session)

Reporting Analyst: Expert Civic Analyst

Document Type: Comprehensive Municipal Meeting Report

Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The meeting was called back to order by the presiding officer [00:04:10](#). The council established a working plan to revise budget figures based on daily changes, email them to members the following morning, and reconvene to reconcile budget requests versus projected revenues.
- **Attendance:** Presiding officers and council members noted in attendance/proceedings include Mr. Hughes, Jessica, Dan, Jim, Bill, and new council budget hearing participant Aubrey Christ (representing BC and Gilkerson).

Substantive Business & Board Action

1. Sheriff's Department & Jail Budget Review

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 00:05:49 Sheriff's Department Budget Review (County General Fund 129 & LIT Sheriff Funds)
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Sheriff Skinner and Nancy.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - The department's overall baseline ask is roughly \$284,000–\$285,000 higher than the previous year (excluding the pension).
 - Discussion focused heavily on overtime tracking, minimum staffing constraints, hospital watch duties for inmates, and state/local reimbursements.
 - The sheriff's pension payment (maximum option discussed at ~\$1.75 million vs. middle-road estimates) was evaluated. The council discussed moving the full pension amount entirely into LIT (Local Income Tax) to gain a clearer picture of the general fund operating budget, noting that current LIT balances can cover the entire amount without exceeding thresholds.
 - Jail operating expenses, medical and food contract increases (both up 3%), and correctional officer turnover were reviewed.
- **Action & Support Documents:** Reviewed for technical and line-item adjustments; pension allocations shifted for planning visibility.

2. Information Technology (IT) Budget Review

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 00:40:59 IT Department Budget Review (Funds 120 & 146)
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Ryan (IT Director).
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - The Justice Center IT fund (146) was successfully eliminated and consolidated into Fund 120, resulting in an overall combined budget decrease of \$146,000 (\$944,21 for the current ask compared to \$1,087,285 last year).
 - Discussion centered on software versus hardware adjustments, Microsoft 365 migration plans, on-premise Exchange server transitions, and a future resiliency/failover plan utilizing dark fiber paths (connecting the highway department and county buildings).
- **Action & Support Documents:** Reviewed and integrated into the overarching IT consolidation framework.

3. Community Corrections Budget Review

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 00:50:08 Community Corrections User Fee & Grant Budgets
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Jane Miranda and Melissa Richie (Financial Manager).
- **Deliberation Summary:**

- Addressed reductions due to an alternative funding source/grant for an alternative fuel/surveillance fleet and drug court supervisor positions.
- Health insurance lines decreased by \$145,000 by utilizing exact auditor office figures rather than inflated historical projections.
- Addressed user fee investments (\$300,000 invested out of \$647,000 via Board of Finance approval) and discussed state grant award timelines versus local cash accounts.
- **Action & Support Documents:** Detailed line adjustments made for FICA, PERF, and grant-funded salaries.

4. Public Defender Budget Review

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 01:14:19 Public Defender Budget Review (Fund 139 & Supplemental Fund 247)
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Sam (Chief Public Defender) and Shelley.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Reviewed compliance mandates from the Indiana Public Defender Commission (CCIA), which requires public defender pay parity with prosecutor deputy averages to prevent penalties (which force reduced caseloads and reliance on outside counsel billed at \$120/hour).
 - Discussed attorney qualification requirements for murders/level-one felonies, part-time status vs. full-time hours worked, and storage container solutions/records retention for files.
- **Action & Support Documents:** Acknowledged CCIA compliance mandates; supplemental fund exceptions noted.

5. Clerk & Election Board Budget Review

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 01:53:39 Clerk, Election Board, and Perpetuation Funds
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Rick (Clerk).
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Noted the elimination of one position in the clerk's general budget for 2027 and utilization of the 4D fund to bridge staffing.
 - Highlighted the success of vote centers, new Microvote encoder devices for poll pads, and robust ballot processing equipment.
 - Discussed clerk perpetuation revenues (~\$50,000/year) and historical under-compensation of clerk staff relative to the courts.
- **Action & Support Documents:** Reviewed operational savings anticipated from upcoming municipal elections.

6. Emergency Medical Services (EMS) Budget Review

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 02:09:01 Delaware County EMS Budget Review

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mike Ashley and Alexis Steel.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Requested funding for wireless service (\$7,200 for cell phones and MDTs) and building maintenance (\$2,000 increase across four stations).
 - Discussed ambulance billing collections (MedBill contract) and reviewed the historical EMS 457 pension/incentive fund balance. Mike Ashley proposed utilizing \$525,000 from the 457 account surplus for county property/building funds while keeping \$100,000 to purchase two new pickup trucks.
- **Action & Support Documents:** Recommendations noted regarding surplus reallocation resolution paths.

7. Commissioners' Budget & Capital Improvements

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 02:43:36 Commissioners' General Budget & DLZ Capital Improvements
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Commissioners / Administration.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Noted a \$53,962 reduction in utility/phone lines due to a comprehensive telecom audit.
 - Addressed increases in liability insurance premiums (\$64,000) and sewer utilities (Munsee Sanitary District rates).
 - Reviewed the DLZ engineering assessment detailing \$3.5 to \$4.25 million in Priority 1 capital needs for the county building (exterior concrete restoration, waterproofing, boiler/HVAC replacements, ADA compliance, and IT server room fire suppression).
 - After public pushback on tax increases for a building fund, the board recommended reducing the line item to **\$750,000** to begin phased repairs.
 - Discussed mental health and developmental disabilities tax levy adjustments (Hillcraft Services and Meridian services allocations).
- **Action & Support Documents:** Line 365 adjusted downward to **\$750,000** for initial capital priorities.

8. Highway & Engineering Department Budget Review

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 03:24:10 Engineer, Cumulative Bridge, Local Road & Street, and Motor Vehicle Highway Budgets
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** County Engineer / Highway Staff.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Reviewed Cumulative Bridge funding for the McGallard Bridge design phase (Bridge 509 matching funds).
 - Local Road and Street budget reduced by \$95,000 (to \$805,000) to align with Baker Tilly revenue projections regarding declining gas tax distributions.

- Converted a retiring labor position into a certified truck driver position (\$51,224), offsetting the cost by reducing longevity lines.
- Reviewed wheel tax fund balances and material allocations for paving.
- **Action & Support Documents:** Adjustments made to overtime and longevity lines to balance reclassified positions.

9. Health Department Budget Review

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 03:54:50 Health Department & Health First Indiana Budgets
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Jamie Bane (Administrator).
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Reported an overall budget reduction of \$16,795 for the Board of Health fund, alongside strategies for Health First Indiana funding.
 - Addressed community partnerships (Recovery Cafe, Muncie Missions Medical Clinic) and discussed the operational scope of vector control (explaining why widespread mosquito truck fogging is limited due to environmental/bee impacts, cost, and short 24-hour efficacy).
- **Action & Support Documents:** Budget accepted as presented; operational metrics noted.

10. Prosecutor's Office & Specialized Funds

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 04:15:22 High-Tech Crimes Unit, Title IV-D, and Pre-Trial Diversion Budgets
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Prosecutor's Office Staff.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - High-Tech Crimes Unit budget adjusted to correct short-term disability lines back to historical baselines (\$203).
 - Title IV-D family support reviewed (reimbursed 100% up to \$111,975 and 66.6% thereafter).
 - Pre-trial diversion user fee fund examined in light of fee revenues, part-time staffing, and software expenses.
- **Action & Support Documents:** Short-term disability line corrected; health insurance allocations audited.

11. Courts, CASA, & Probation Budget Review

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 04:38:44 Circuit/Superior Courts, CASA, Adult Probation, and User Fee Budgets
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Judge Calhoun, Judge Douglas Moore, Karen Zable, and Jeff Answer.
- **Deliberation Summary:**

- CASA program presented significant increases in CHINS filings (80% increase over 4 years) and detailed travel miles driven for out-of-county placements. Shifted personnel lines due to the expiration of federal VOCA grant funding.
- Courts highlighted surging costs for psychological/competency evaluations (\$12,000+/month) and jury trials (doubled daily rates, mandatory mileage, and numerous pending murder trials requiring extended panels).
- Probation department noted state-mandated salary schedules, educational/military incentive lines (Line 136), and user fee balances (Fund 2100).
- **Action & Support Documents:** Technical adjustments flagged for collaborative review tomorrow.

12. Auditor & County Council Budgets

- **Item Identifier & Title:** 06:01:53 Auditor's Office & County Council Operating Budgets
- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Auditor Ed, Lisa, and Council Members.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Reviewed staff salaries, 40-hour work week adjustments, overtime/part-time projections, and contracted software expenses (VIP/Guts, OpenGov, Beacon, and Bruce's Unique Computing contract at \$125,000).
 - Discussed un Funded state mandates (GAP reporting consultants totaling ~\$218,000) and software module configurations for permitting and inventory tracking.
 - Council budget reduced by \$3,850 via cuts to professional services, contractual services, legal publications, and food/lodging lines.
- **Action & Support Documents:** Consolidated software and operating lines queued for final reconciliation.

Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- *Note: The provided transcript consists entirely of a municipal budget work session between the County Council, Commissioners, and department heads. No dedicated open public comment period or citizen forum was conducted during this transcript session.*

Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:** Department heads were instructed to review their unspent salary lines and prepare realistic "give-back" estimates for morning reconciliation.
- **Adjournment:**
 - Motion to recess offered by Dan, seconded by Jessica.
 - **Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.

- **Next Session:** Meeting recessed to reconvene the following morning at 10:30 AM 06:51:52.

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